V

PART FIVE · ✚

The Fall of the United States

About eighteen years, from a stadium sermon in 2033 to a constitution in 2051. Almost every step went through a vote, a referendum or an agreement.

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The world starts here

The United States became the Covenant Empire of America over about eighteen years. It started with a stadium sermon in 2033 and ended in 2051, when the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast were written into the constitution as the three branches of government. Almost every step went through a vote, a referendum or an agreement (**TL**). Nobody in Eden's lifetime remembers the country before. The oldest person in her cast was born around 2035, into its last few years.

From this part on, the companion is about your world, and the rules change slightly. Anything your files establish carries a source tag and no label. Everything else is labeled at the start of the sentence it governs: INFERENCE for what the files imply without saying, POSSIBLE for ideas that aren't canon, OPEN QUESTION for what you still have to decide, CONFLICT where two files disagree, SUPERSEDED where older material no longer controls, and DECIDED for a call you've made. The Final Rulings outrank everything. Where a file and a ruling disagree, the ruling wins and the page says so.

SOURCE TAGS

TL Timeline · TR Trials · TR-orig original Trials file · DOM Dominions · MEN Men in the Empire · CR Crownward · DR3 Draft Three · WR Writing Rules · FR Final Rulings · AM Audit Master · Ruling, the October 23 calibration

DECIDED CANON

Solomon is sixteen. Leah is younger than Eden. Thomas left voluntarily (**FR 3**). Celeste has no proof Miriam is alive (**FR 16**). Leah sat for an assessment.

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* The canon register, at the back.

TKC: TL · CR

2025 TO 2051

YEAR	EVENT	SOURCE
2025–2031	The Fracture Years. A contested election leaves two men claiming the presidency at once. Automated labor wipes out forty percent of working-class jobs. Domestic attacks on federal buildings go uncontained, and a climate disaster makes the Gulf Coast uninhabitable. Faith in federal institutions collapses, and church attendance triples.	TL
2031	Evangelical megachurches, conservative political action groups and private militias organize as the Covenant Coalition. "America was great when it was godly. Return to God. Return to greatness." They run candidates at every level at once.	TL
2033	Elias Vane, a little-known Georgia preacher, preaches *Thy Kingdom Come* for six hours to 400,000 people at The Gathering House, the former Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta. Every Coalition network carries it live.	TL
2035	Vane wins a Senate seat from Georgia, and within eighteen months he effectively controls the legislative agenda. Celeste Parish is born about now (INFERENCE).	TL
2039	California, Oregon and New York attempt to secede. The federal government calls it treason, and a two-year standoff follows.	TL
2041	The Partition Agreement brings the three states back with "regional autonomy," dismantled about four years later. Vane's Restoration Act passes Congress narrowly, under conditions later described as coercion.	TL
2043	Vane declares the United States dissolved and reborn as the Covenant Empire of America and takes the title First Elector. The Crownward is established over Washington, D.C.	TL, CR
2044	The Dominion Act makes the states Twelve Dominions, each under a Governor-Prelate. Atlanta becomes Aurelia, seat of Aurem.	TL
2048	Elias, 52, marries Sera Callum, 28, a Vowed woman and Temple scholar. The first Anointed marriage.	TL
2051	The Triune Rule makes the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast the three constitutional governing bodies.	TL

2054 to 2104

TKC: TL · DOM · FR 35–36 · FR 39

YEAR	EVENT	SOURCE
2054	Vane becomes Emperor by a referendum returning 94 percent approval, and founds the House of Vane.	TL
2058	The Commonwife quota system is piloted in Red Earth.	DOM
2061	Elias dies of heart failure at 65. The Temple canonizes him within the year, his face goes on the currency and his sermon becomes required curriculum. The same year, Elias's elder child, the rightful successor and Dorian's parent, is removed.	TL, FR 35–36
2062	Crest Vane takes the throne at 34. The Commonwife quotas go Empire-wide, and the Ungoverned are designated criminal.	TL
2065	The first Covenant Trials	TL
2077	Azrael Vane born	TL
2079	Judah Vane born	TL
2085	Crest dies mid-cycle. Dorian takes the throne at 40, and that year's Trial is cancelled.	TL, FR 39
2098	Azrael, 21, finds a ledger in the east wing archive	TL
2100	Azrael is declared dead. The ledger and the Covenant of Dissent vanish the same week.	TL
2104	The 39th Covenant Trial	TL

CONFLICT

The timeline introduces the Commonwife quotas under Crest in 2062, and the Dominions file says Red Earth piloted them in 2058. **INFERENCE** Both hold if the 2058 pilot ran under Elias in one Dominion and Crest took it Empire-wide in 2062.

THE YEAR I WANT A SCENE IN, AND WHOSE EYES IT'S THROUGH

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE YEAR I WANT A SCENE IN, AND WHOSE EYES IT'S THROUGH

Official version, lived reality

TKC: TL · AM · FR 19

Everyone in Eden's world learned the left column in school. Where a character sits between the two columns says a lot about who she is. The Empire's phrasing is what people would actually say aloud, so it's the version to use in dialogue (AM).

WHAT THE EMPIRE CALLS IT	WHAT HAPPENED
THE FRACTURE YEARS, WHICH GOD ENDED	Six years of overlapping disasters that a well-organized coalition was ready to inherit
THE RESTORATION	A 400-page law that made rights conditional, passed under coercion nobody had to name
REGIONAL AUTONOMY, GRANTED IN MERCY	A four-year holding pattern for three states that tried to leave, dismantled once the leverage was gone
PUBLIC MANDATE, 94 PERCENT	A referendum controlled tightly enough to produce the number it wanted
REORGANIZED FOR ACCURACY AND UNITY	The press became a branch of government
CITIZENSHIP CLARIFIED THROUGH COVENANT	A woman's legal standing became dependent on whether a man has married her
A CELEBRATION OF THE EMPIRE'S FINEST WOMEN	A televised selection producing one Anointed Wife a year, and eleven women married down the elite ladder (FR 19)
A SUDDEN MEDICAL EVENT	The phrase the Empire uses for Azrael in 2100 and for Petra in 2104

THREE LINES A SCHOOLTEACHER IN AURELIA SAYS ABOUT THE FALL, WORD FOR WORD

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THREE LINES A SCHOOLTEACHER IN AURELIA SAYS ABOUT THE FALL, WORD FOR WORD

The legal root

TKC: TL

OPEN QUESTION

The Restoration Act is the legal root of almost everything in Eden's life. It passed Congress, so the Empire's founding argument is that nothing illegal happened (TL).

The Restoration Act

PUBLIC LAW · 2041

AUTHORED BY SENATOR ELIAS VANE OF GEORGIA · PASSED BY THE CONGRESS OF THE UNITED STATES

TITLE I · RIGHTS	*conditional on standing, compliance and designation*
TITLE II · MARRIAGE	*a legal and theological designation*
TITLE III · CITIZENSHIP	*a woman's, dependent on marital status*
TITLE IV · THE PRESS	*"reorganized for accuracy and unity"*
PREAMBLE	_____

Ten years after Title IV the same apparatus is a branch of government, and today it controls forty percent of a Covenant Daughter's score. The Binding, the Commonwife quota and the Anointed marriage all descend from Title II. Unbound is a legal category with a file because of Title III.

PASSED

OPEN QUESTION

What does the preamble say? You'll want the actual wording for any scene where a character quotes the Restoration.

DRAFT THE PREAMBLE, IN THE ACT'S OWN VOICE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

DRAFT THE PREAMBLE, IN THE ACT'S OWN VOICE

Grandmothers and documents

TKC: TL · TR · DOM · FR 35–44

Nobody in the cast lived through the Fall as an adult. What survives comes down through grandmothers and through the House of Vane's own papers.

CELESTE PARISH · TL	About nine in 2044, she remembers the renaming of Atlanta and her own grandmother crying when they changed the signs. She watched the Empire take her mother's identity through a Commonwife marriage, then raised Miriam alone under Unbound designation rather than let it happen again. The real name of the city is the last thing she says to Eden before the Crownward. (Volume Two, Celeste.)
SERA MONTOYA'S GRANDMOTHER · TR	She was at the last protest before the Partition Agreement ended Pacific's resistance in 2041. She tells it to Sera as a warning and not a hero story: the difference between impact and loss is knowing when and how.
PACIFIC'S GENERATIONS · DOM	The people who remember trying to leave raised children who grew up with parents who'd tried and failed, and their grandchildren grew up knowing the story. The Empire still checks every Pacific girl's Designation for signs that the secession story survived in her.
ZARA VOSS'S GRANDMOTHER · TR	She has a real name the desert knows and the Empire doesn't. She raised Zara in Sable Reach and the desert beyond it.
THE HOUSE OF VANE · TL, FR 35–44	The family keeps documents instead of grandmothers' stories, and those documents are the most dangerous things in the Crownward.

Celeste, to Eden, before the Crownward

The real name of the city.

✣

Write the line she actually says on the facing page.

WRITING

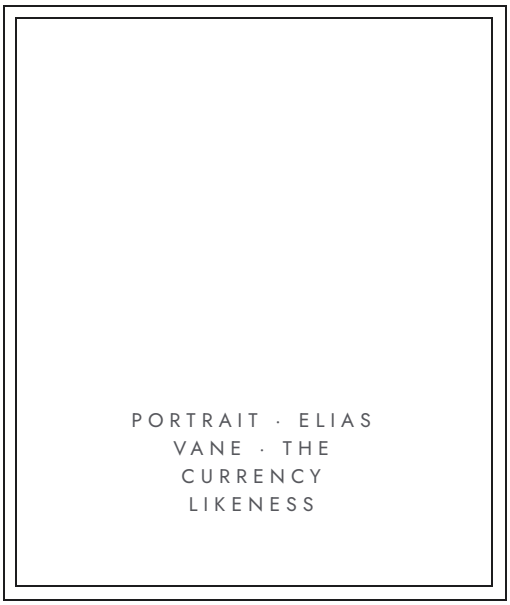
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WHAT CELESTE'S GRANDMOTHER LOST WHEN THE SIGNS CHANGED, AND WHO SHE WAS BEFORE THE FALL

Elias Vane

TKC: TL · CR · AM

c. 1996–2061 · First Elector 2043 · Emperor 2054–2061 · canonized



Founder Record

HOUSE OF VANE · I

BORN
c. 1996, Georgia (INFERENCE from his ages)

SENATE
2035

RESTORATION ACT
2041

FIRST ELECTOR
2043

EMPEROR
2054, by referendum

DIED
2061, heart failure, 65

WHAT THE FILES SAY	A little-known Georgia preacher until the 2033 sermon (TL). His face is on the currency, and *Thy Kingdom Come* is required curriculum in every Dominion school. The Temple teaches that God chose him to restore the nation and that his descendants carry the anointing forward (CR).
HIS METHOD	INTERPRETATION The old companion's reading holds. He never took anything until refusing him would cost more than giving in. He ran candidates everywhere, made himself the man every faction needed, outlasted the secession instead of winning it, and wrote the law himself (AM).

WRITING

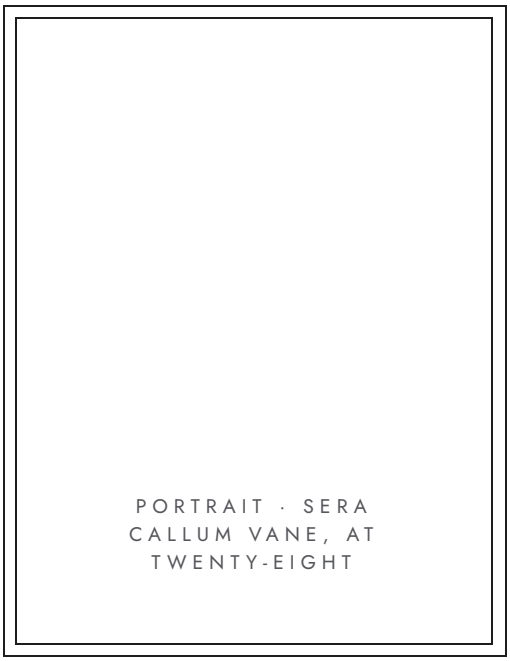
FROM THE FACING PAGE

ONE LINE OF THE 2033 SERMON EVERY SCHOOLCHILD KNOWS

Sera Callum Vane

TKC: TL

Vowed woman · Temple scholar · the first Anointed Wife, 2048



WHAT THE FILES SAY	A Vowed woman and Temple scholar who married Elias in 2048, when she was 28. She became the most powerful woman in the Empire's history while appearing entirely devoted to her husband. She wrote most of his domestic policy, and no official record says so (TL).
HER LEGACY	Her marriage is the template for the Covenant Trials.

CONFLICT

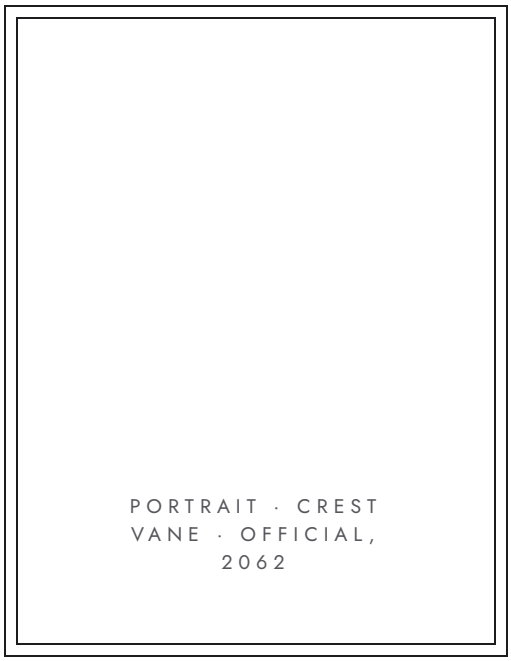
The timeline says she came from "the Northern Dominion." None of the Twelve Dominions has that name. **OPEN QUESTION** Where did she come from?

THE POLICY SHE WROTE THAT HAS HIS NAME ON IT

TKC: TL · FR 35 · FR 37 · FR 39 · FR 40

Crest Vane

Emperor 2062–2085 · Dorian's uncle (**FR 35**)



WHAT THE FILES SAY	Elias's son. He took the throne at 34, so he was born around 2028, twenty years before his father's Anointed marriage (INFERENCE). Cold and procedural. He manages people instead of inspiring them, and under him the Empire grows more efficient and more brutal (**TL**).
WHAT HE BUILT	The Commonwife quotas, the criminal category of the Ungoverned, and the Trials.

HIS CLAIM	Survivorship, not birth order (**FR 35, 39**). He knew about his elder sibling's removal, didn't arrange it and didn't prevent it (**FR 37**).
THE ONE THING HE DID	He preserved the documents, leaving them where the east wing archive would someday be inventoried (**FR 40**).

WHY CREST KEPT THE DOCUMENTS

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHY CREST KEPT THE DOCUMENTS

TKC: TL · FR 35–38 · FR 44 · RULING

The removed heir and Dorian Vane

THE REMOVED HEIR	Elias's elder child, and the rightful successor. Removed in 2061, when Dorian was still a child (**FR 35–36**). **OPEN QUESTION** What did the heir know or do that made removal necessary? The rulings cover how it happened and why Dorian was spared, and not why the heir had to go.
DORIAN VANE · EMPEROR SINCE 2085	The removed heir's son. He took the throne at 40 and is 59 in 2104 (**TL, Ruling**). He was spared because a child's claim can be supervised. Removing him would have needed a public reason, and raising him inside the house needed none (**FR 38**). He has known since 2061 that the documents name Elias (**FR 44**). Under him the Broadcast became genuinely sophisticated, and the Trials became the most-watched event of the year (**TL**).





SUPERSEDED The Crownward file gives Dorian's age as 61. The ruling uses 59, which matches the timeline and the Audit Master. The Crownward file also calls Crest Dorian's father. Under FR 35, Crest is his uncle.

WHAT DORIAN HAS KNOWN SINCE 2061, AND THE FIRST TIME HE ALMOST SAID IT

WRITING

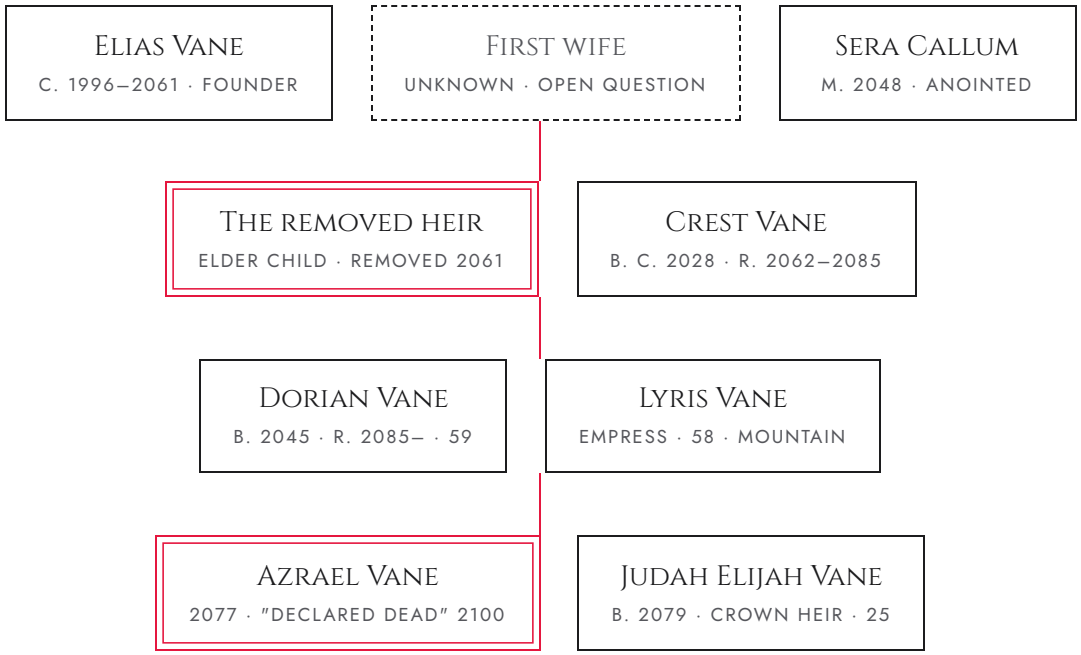
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WHAT DORIAN HAS KNOWN SINCE 2061, AND THE FIRST TIME HE ALMOST SAID IT

TKC: TL · FR 35 · CR · WR

OPEN QUESTION

The family tree



The removed heir is Dorian's parent, and Crest is Dorian's uncle (**FR 35**). **INFERENCE** Dorian's birth year follows from his age at accession. The marks show the 2061 removal and the 2100 "sudden medical event."

WHO WAS ELIAS'S FIRST WIFE, AND HOW DOES THE OFFICIAL HISTORY TREAT HER?

The ledger and the Covenant of Dissent

TKC: TL · FR 40–44

2098	During a Crown advisory access period, Azrael found a ledger in the east wing archive. It ties the Empire's founding documents to a series of deliberate removals, which the Covenant of Purpose describes as God's order and the ledger describes as something else. It had sat there unmoved since 2085, because nobody was looking (**FR 41**).
PUT IT BACK	He took it to his father, who told him to put it back. Azrael kept it and went looking for its companion, the Covenant of Dissent, which Elias wrote in the same year and the same hand, as the theological counter-argument to everything the Empire was built on.
2100	Dorian removed both documents the week Azrael was declared dead (**FR 42**). He'd told Azrael to put the ledger back because a document Azrael had read and returned would be one Dorian controlled. Destroying it would have told Azrael it mattered (**FR 43**).

East Wing Archive · Holdings Card

CATALOGUED UNTIL 2100

ITEM	*Covenant of Dissent, in the hand of E. Vane*
COMPANION ITEM	*Ledger, uncatalogued*
LAST WITHDRAWN	_____
STATUS	*missing, the week of 2100 in which A. Vane was declared dead*

WITHDRAWN

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT THE "DELIBERATE REMOVALS" WERE: PEOPLE, POPULATIONS, RECORDS, OR ALL THREE

Working Questions

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

PART IX LOG

1 · WHAT DOES THE COVENANT OF DISSENT ARGUE, IN A SENTENCE ELIAS COULD HAVE PREACHED? WHY DID HE WRITE IT: DOUBT, INSURANCE, VANITY, OR SOMETHING ELSE?

2 · WHERE DID SERA CALLUM COME FROM, IF NOT A "NORTHERN DOMINION"?

3 · HOW DO SCHOOLS IN PACIFIC TEACH THE PARTITION, AND HOW DOES THAT DIFFER FROM WHAT PACIFIC GRANDMOTHERS SAY AT HOME?

4 · WHICH LINES FROM THE 2033 SERMON DOES EVERY SCHOOLCHILD KNOW BY HEART?

VI

PART SIX ·

Building the Empire

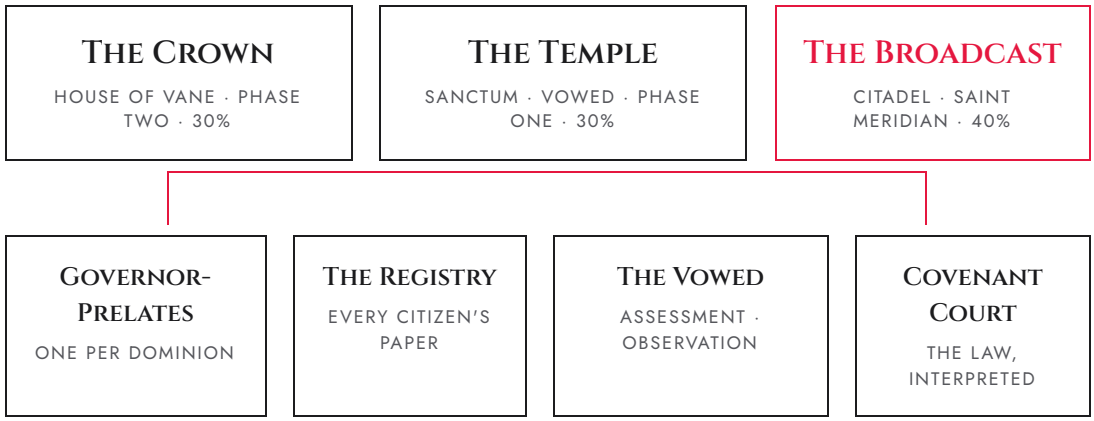
Three constitutional bodies, twelve Dominions, a Registry that holds everyone's paper, a Temple that tells each woman what she is, and the religion people practice where nobody is watching.

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ii · The Crown and the House of Vane	482
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v · The Broadcast, the Governors, the Registry	488
vi · Men, labor and the economy	492
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viii · Women, marriage and the household order	506

Three bodies, one score

TKC: TL · TR · CR

In 2051 the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast were made the three governing bodies of the Empire. What had worked informally since 2043 became constitutional, and the Broadcast stopped being a network of Coalition media companies and became a branch of government (TL).



HOW THE TRIALS ARE SPLIT	The Temple runs Phase One and the Crown runs Phase Two. Endurance belongs to the terrain. The Covenant Score is weighted 30 percent Temple, 30 percent Crown and 40 percent Broadcast (TR).
THE SECRET	The Broadcast's share is never disclosed, because the public would be angry to learn that a broadcaster outweighs the Church in choosing the Empire's most powerful woman (TR).

WHO IN THE CAST KNOWS THE FORTY PERCENT, AND HOW THEY FOUND OUT

TKC: TL · AM · RULING · FR 35 · FR 39 · FR 41 · CR · MEN · WR

Four rulers, three methods

Every Emperor descends from Elias Vane, who founded the House in 2054 (TL). The Temple teaches that God chose Elias and that the bloodline carries the anointing forward, so the family's status is theological as well as political (CR).

RULER	YEARS	HOW HE HELD POWER	SOURCE
ELIAS VANE	First Elector 2043, Emperor 2054–2061	Belief. A preacher who made people want what he wanted.	TL, AM
CREST VANE	2062–2085	Procedure: quotas, designations, criminal categories and the Trials	TL
DORIAN VANE	2085 to now, 59 in 2104	Performance. He brought back the spectacle and made the Trials the year's biggest event.	TL, Ruling
JUDAH ELIJAH VANE	Crown Heir, 25 in 2104	He hasn't yet. He was raised by the Temple as much as by his parents.	TL

SUCCESSION	By survivorship and the absence of any other recognized claimant (FR 39). Crest inherited after his elder sibling was removed in 2061. Dorian, that sibling's son, inherited after Crest died (FR 35, 39). When Azrael was declared dead in 2100, the line passed to Judah (TL).
THE HEIR'S MARRIAGE	A matter of state. Dorian has pushed Judah toward an Anointed Wife since he turned 23, because an unmarried heir is an heir whose loyalties are still unwritten (CR). Elite men usually marry between 25 and 35. The Trials exist partly because of Judah's reluctance, to make the choice feel like an honor instead of pressure (MEN).
ADVISORY ACCESS	Young members of the House take part in "Crown advisory access periods," which is how Azrael got legitimate access to the east wing archive (TL, FR 41).
LYRIS VANE	Empress, 58, and the most sophisticated political operator in the Empire. She's spent thirty years performing perfect Anointed Wifehood while running the Crownward's domestic and diplomatic machinery, and lobbied through Dorian for a decade to shape the Anointed Wife's legal protections, framing every gain as his gift (CR). She came from Mountain Dominion (WR).

SUPERSEDED The Crownward file calls Crest Dorian's father. Under FR 35, Crest is Dorian's uncle.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

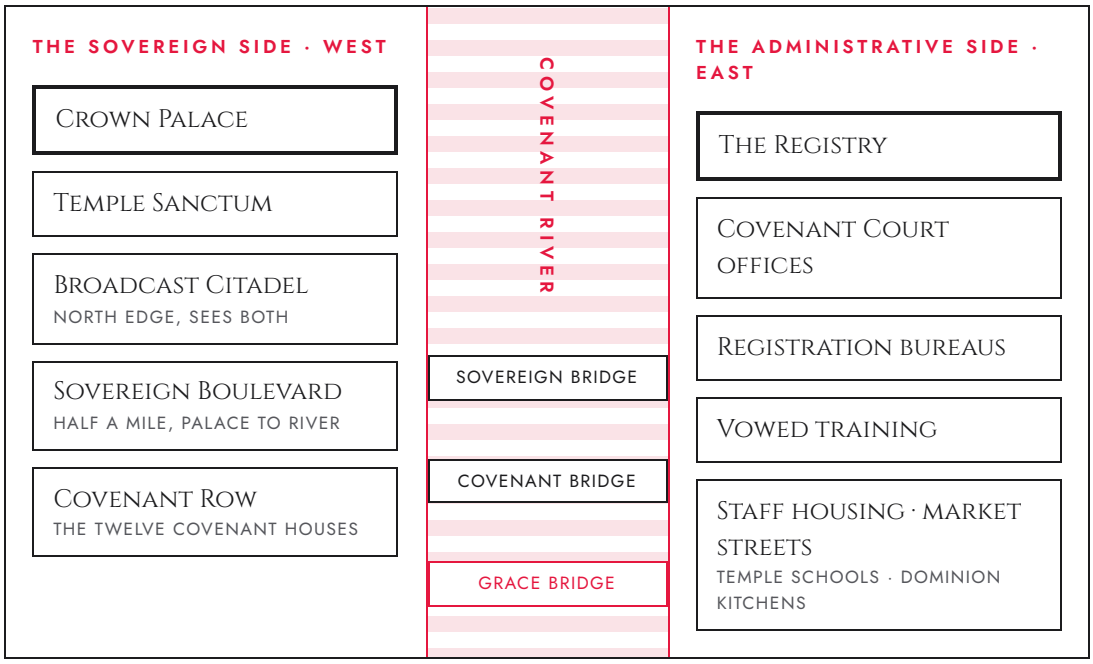
HOW DID LYRIS, A WOMAN FROM MOUNTAIN, BECOME DORIAN'S WIFE? WHAT DID THE TRIALS HAVE TO DO WITH IT?

TKC: CR

RESEARCH
ARLINGTON, VIRGINIA

The Capital

The Crownward is built over Washington, D.C., formally established in 2043. Elias occupied the old capital instead of moving it, because you don't abandon the seat of the thing you claim to restore. Most people in 2104 have never seen a photograph of Washington (**CR**). The Potomac is now the Covenant River, and it divides the city.



THE BRIDGES	The Sovereign Bridge is the widest and appears on the currency. The Covenant Bridge is narrower and used by staff. The Grace Bridge is the oldest, never fully renovated, and has blind spots in Broadcast coverage, so it's where people go when they don't want to be filmed.
RESEARCH	In the real city central Washington sits on the Potomac's east bank, and the west bank is Arlington, Virginia. Read literally, the Sovereign Side stands where Arlington National Cemetery and the Pentagon are now. **POSSIBLE** Somebody in the Crownward knows the Crown Palace is built over the old national cemetery.

The order nobody writes down

TKC: CR

The Crownward has a rigid social order that nobody writes down and everybody enforces (CR).

THE HOUSE OF VANE	At the top.
THE ANOINTED COURT	About forty families whose standing is measured by how close they live to the Palace. They attend quarterly audiences with the Emperor, and the Temple High Prelates sit among them.
THE ADMINISTRATIVE CLASS	The senior staff of the Crown, Temple and Broadcast. Most of their wives hold Stewardwife designation.
THEIR DAUGHTERS	The Crownward's daughters who enter the Trials are rarely the most celebrated candidates, and they're almost always the most dangerous (CR).

WHAT SOMEONE ON THE GRACE BRIDGE CAN DO THAT THEY CAN'T DO ANYWHERE ELSE

A WALK ACROSS THE CROWNWARD, WEST TO EAST, IN EDEN'S FIRST WEEK

TKC: DR3 · CR · DOM · MEN · TR · TL · FR 30 · FR 33

Ministers, Vowed and the Prelate

The Temple is a church and a branch of government. In Eden's world it shows up as ministers, Vowed women and doctrine. Its scripture is read from the Book of Covenant (DR3), and the Temple Sanctum in the Crownward is its seat (CR).

MINISTERS	Senior Minister Bell is the model: a man who signs Binding certificates, sponsors Assessment candidates, and prays God will close every door not intended for a girl (DR3).
THE VOWED	Women in Temple service, who run most of the Empire's contact with women. A Vowed officer assesses every Aurem girl at eighteen (DOM). They conduct the quarterly household assessments in Aurem's Commonwife homes (MEN), run the Regional Assessments, and observe, examine and interview the Covenant Daughters (TR). In Red Earth they attend school performances as "pastoral care" (DOM).
THE CROWNWARD VOWED	The Temple's elite and the Empire's most efficient intelligence network. The Temple calls it spiritual discernment and the Crown uses it as surveillance, and it's never written down anywhere the Empire could confiscate it (CR).
LEAVING	The designation can be left through marriage. Delphine's mother went from Vowed to Bonded Wife, and Hannah was Vowed before she became House Mother (TR, FR 30). Sera Callum was Vowed when Elias married her (TL). Hannah's daughter Naomi has one year left in Vowed education (TL).

The Prelate

TKC: DR3 · CR · DOM · MEN · TR · TL · FR 30 · FR 33

PORTRAIT · THE PRELATE · WORKING NAME AURELIA

THE PRELATE

She heads the Crownward's Vowed. She's 67, has served three Emperors, and knows better than anyone in the city how power actually works. She assessed Judah's spiritual formation personally. In the Trial's first week she'll reach a conclusion about Eden that she shares with no one, the Emperor included. She anoints the Crown Heir's bride (**CR**).

The files call her Prelate Naomi. FR 33 renames her so Hannah's daughter keeps the name. **POSSIBLE** Prelate Aurelia is the working name. She is never Huldah.

WHAT THE PRELATE CONCLUDES ABOUT EDEN IN THE FIRST WEEK, AND WHAT SHE DOES WITH IT

TKC: CR · DOM · TR · TL · DR3 · MEN

Paper and cameras

THE BROADCAST	State media and the third branch. Its Citadel stands in the Crownward, and its studios, where Trial scores are announced, sit in old Midtown Manhattan in Saint Meridian (DOM). It holds 40 percent of the Covenant Score, including "narrative priority decisions" by the Broadcast Director. It edits the Civic Debates for Dominion release and builds a story around every candidate in real time. When a candidate's intelligence becomes the story instead of her compliance, it runs the "Eve narrative," which implies and never accuses (TR).
GOVERNOR-PRELATES	One political and religious office per Dominion (TL). They choose each Covenant Daughter from the top three of the Regional Assessment, and in practice take whoever the Crown has quietly signaled it prefers (TR). Gulf's first lasted fourteen months. Lone's has always been born in Texas. Pacific's was appointed by Dorian. Ardenne's has mostly stopped trying to fix the marriage records from outside Ashford (DOM).
THE REGISTRY	On the Administrative Side. Every citizen's Imperial record: birth designations, marriage registrations, Covenant Scores, Designation results and deaths. Only the Crown Palace is guarded more heavily. Whoever controls what the Registry says about you controls something more basic than law, faith or the Broadcast, and Eden will understand this before most people in the story (CR).
THE COVENANT COURT	Interprets Imperial law, with offices on the Administrative Side and secondary chambers in Blessed Shore, where the law "gets interpreted, refined, and weaponized" (CR, DOM).
SURVEILLANCE	Cameras and screens everywhere in the seat cities. The Covenant Houses are wired in every common area but not the bedrooms, a deliberate illusion of privacy that keeps candidates manageable (CR). Pacific has more cameras per block than any other Dominion. Eden's file reads "Exceptional intellect. Monitor closely," later "Selected for Trial. Monitor closely" (TL).
THE GAPS	The Grace Bridge, the Ardenne hollows, the Sable desert, west Lone's distances, Saint Meridian's density, and the Mountain terrain where Endurance runs mostly without cameras (CR, DOM, TR).

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO RUNS THE REGISTRY, AND WHO HAS EVER CHANGED WHAT IT SAYS ABOUT A PERSON

TKC: DR3 · TL · MEN · TR · CR · DOM

OPEN QUESTION

The forms

Household Return

REGISTRY FORM H-1 · AUREM

ONE COPY TO THE TEMPLE, ONE TO THE CROWN · ALL FIELDS REQUIRED

HOUSEHOLD OF	*Parish, Celeste · Unbound*
ADULT MALE AUTHORITY	*"deceased" · returned with the word circled, next adult male requested*
DEPENDENTS	_____
RECLASSIFICATION	*six years pending*
AUTHORITY, ON RESUBMISSION	*Zion Osei, eighteen*

RETURNED

THE AUTHORITY LINE	Household forms demand an adult male authority. Celeste wrote "deceased" on the line, and the form came back with the word circled and a request for the next adult male (DR3). Solomon's vocational form kept coming back to the house until Zion, at eighteen, declared himself the authority (TL, DR3).
RECLASSIFYING	A woman reclassifying her household under her own registration has to prove the arrangement is permanent (TL). Celeste's took six years.
MOVING	Moving between Dominions requires Crown authorization, technically available and practically difficult (MEN).
CITATIONS	Any Ungoverned citation disqualifies a woman from the Covenant Registry (TR). OPEN QUESTION What else does it do? Criminal record, designation, or both?
DEATHS	Registered within 48 hours in the Crownward and 24 in Meridian (CR, DOM).

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

A FORM FROM THE OSEI HOUSEHOLD I WANT ON THE PAGE, FIELD BY FIELD

TKC: MEN · DOM · TL

Control by structure

The Empire controls women through designation and men through structure. Men are told they're free, and the control sits in housing, careers and marriage approvals (MEN).

CLASS	WHO THEY ARE	MARRIAGE
COMMON MEN	The labor and service class, registered to their Dominion	Expected by 21. Unmarried men past 22 stay in labor dormitories. Within caste and region.
BONDED MEN	Mid-tier administrators and skilled professionals, steered by Crown labor allocation	Between 21 and 25, from Unbound and Commonwife-eligible women, with Crown approval
COVENANT MEN	Crown officers, Temple leadership, Broadcast directors, senior military	Between 25 and 35. Their wives are Anointed.
CONSCRIPT MEN	Common boys whose scores flag them. Officially they don't exist.	Crown approval at the Covenant Man level, for life

THE IMPERIAL EDUCATION TRACK	A common boy whose Designation scores come back exceptional gets a visit from a Crown education officer within three months, offering a scholarship. The family can decline, and declining routes him to the worst labor for life. Accepting makes him Crown-adjacent for life (MEN). (Volume Two, Solomon.)
THE COVENANT DECLARATION	At 18, common men register a public statement of loyalty and readiness for service and marriage. Elite men register theirs at the end of the Track (MEN).
TWELVE ECONOMIES	Irongate manufacturing. Lone oil and space infrastructure. Mountain classified operations, extraction and military capacity. Gulf tourism, rebranded "cultural pilgrimage." Meridian law and administration. Vane the Broadcast (DOM).

INFERENCE The forty percent of working-class jobs lost to automation in the Fracture Years never came back, which is what makes Imperial service look like opportunity to a common man.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

HOW AN AUREM COMMON MAN GETS AUTHORIZATION TO MOVE, AND HOW OFTEN IT'S GRANTED

TKC: CR · TL · DR3 · TR

The official religion, in one line

Preached every week in every Temple

The husband leads, the wife supports, the household reflects divine order in miniature.

✣

THE OFFICIAL THEOLOGY OF MARRIAGE (**CR**)

THE VANE ANOINTING	God chose Elias to restore the nation, and the bloodline carries divine sanction (**CR**). Elias was canonized within a year, "not quite sainthood but close enough" (**TL**).
THE HOUSE JUDGES FAIRLY	Bell tells Celeste "The House always judges fairly," and Celeste answers "The House calls whom it calls." Before the scores Bell speaks about "divine order, talent as stewardship, and elevation as burden," and closes with "May every daughter receive with grace the portion appointed to her" (**DR3**).
THE HOUSE VIRTUES	The banners in the Aurelia Temple atrium read obedience, discernment, modesty, stewardship and endurance (**DR3**).
SELECTION AS REVELATION	The Broadcast frames the Trials as a revelation and never a competition: anointing, covenant, calling, worthy, chosen. A competition can be rigged, and a revelation can't (**TR**).
BEING BOUND AS SERVICE	"Every girl in Aurem wanted to be Bound. It was the only way they knew how to serve." Covenant Candidacy is "the closest thing a woman could get to godliness" (**DR3**).

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH VERSES ARE CARVED OVER THE DOORS OF THE AURELIA TEMPLE AND THE SANCTUM

TKC: TL · AM · DR3

PART IV, THE SLAVE BIBLE

Four documents

THY KINGDOM COME · 2033	Six hours, preached by Elias at The Gathering House. Required curriculum in every Dominion school since 2061 (TL). **INTERPRETATION** The old companion reads it as a familiar prayer taken literally in public for the first time. Nobody in the stadium heard a coup. They heard their own prayer said aloud by a man who wasn't embarrassed by it (AM).
THE COVENANT OF PURPOSE	A founding document. It describes a series of deliberate removals as God's order, and the east wing ledger describes the same removals as something else (TL). Celeste can recite it (AM).
THE COVENANT OF DISSENT	Written by Elias in the same hand and the same year, as the theological counter-argument to everything the Empire was built on. Catalogued until 2100, when it disappeared the same week as the ledger. Judah has been looking for it since before his brother's exile (TL).
THE BOOK OF COVENANT	The book Bell reads from at the Assessment. It includes Proverbs 31.29, "Many daughters have done virtuously, but thou excellest them all," in King James wording (DR3). **OPEN QUESTION** A full Protestant Bible, an abridged edition on the 1807 model, or scripture bound with the Empire's own founding texts?

PASSAGE	WHAT THE ASSESSMENT MADE OF IT (DR3)
HONOR THY FATHER AND THY MOTHER (EXOD 20.12)	A question about reporting an Unbound woman who housed her children without male authority
THE WIDOW'S OIL (2 KGS 4)	An argument for household rationing
ESTHER'S CROWN	Proof a woman could influence government, "so long as she was beautiful, obedient, and prepared to die for the privilege"
PROVERBS 31	Printed on the first page and read before the scores

Eden's read: "Facts might earn professional placement. Knowing which facts the House needed her to believe could carry her farther" (DR3).

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE PASSAGE OF THE COVENANT OF PURPOSE ABOUT THE REMOVALS, IN THE EMPIRE'S OWN VOICE

TKC: DOM · MEN

What people actually practice

In every Dominion people do things around the official rites that the Empire doesn't know about, tolerates because stopping them would cost too much, or eventually approves because it already lost (DOM, MEN).

DOMINION	PRACTICE	WHAT IT IS	THE EMPIRE'S POSITION
AUREM	The Salt Ceremony	The bride's mother or grandmother washes her hands in salt water the night before her Binding and tells her the truth about marriage	Doesn't know it exists
AUREM	The old way of burial	Three days, family-led, no Empire officiant: the Telling, the Feeding, the Release. Red clay packed down by family hands.	Doesn't know. The paperwork is filed anyway.
AUREM	The Speaking	The night before a boy's Declaration, each man present tells him one true thing about being a man in Aurelia. The boy can't speak.	Unregulated
AUREM	Kitchens	Recipes that "looked like submission and tasted like memory"	Never thought the kitchen worth watching
GULF	Music in worship	Live music at Bindings, against three ordinances, classed "ceremonial expression within approved parameters"	Tolerated for tourism money
GULF	The Last Free Night	The women of the family dance, drink and tell the bride the truth	Never on paper

WHICH OF THESE MY CHARACTERS HAVE DONE, SEEN OR ONLY HEARD ABOUT

What people actually practice, continued

TKC: DOM · MEN

DOMINION	PRACTICE	WHAT IT IS	THE EMPIRE'S POSITION
GULF	The Procession	At 14, girls walk the boulevard in white, and the crowd turns it into a second line	Can't be stopped without a Broadcast incident
GULF	Funerals	Three days of open house, a second line to the grave, then the Quiet, an hour of silence	Approved in 2052
ARDENNE	Hollow marriages	A community declaration and a broom jump	Records left incomplete
ARDENNE	The First Winter Work, the Sitting	A real job in the community's survival at 13 or 14. Sitting with the dead through the night.	Unregulated
MERIDIAN	Reading Circles	Officially Temple Bible studies. Actually a legal-literacy network for Stewardwives, running since 2069.	Doesn't know what they are
MERIDIAN	The record	Before his Declaration, a father walks his son through the family's complete Imperial record	Within the rules

WHICH OF THESE MY CHARACTERS HAVE DONE, SEEN OR ONLY HEARD ABOUT

TKC: DOM · MEN

WHAT PEOPLE ACTUALLY PRACTICE, CONTINUED

DOMINION	PRACTICE	WHAT IT IS	THE EMPIRE'S POSITION
VANE	Ghost Marriages, the Ghost Declaration	Unions outside registration, and a boy's private statement of what he actually intends	Doesn't know they exist
IRONGATE	The Kitchen	The women's mutual aid network	Never mapped by the Vowed
IRONGATE	The Placement, the First Shift	A girl's work assessed at 14, a boy's first adult shift at 18	Unregulated
IRONGATE	Music	Blues and jazz, "morally ambiguous musical forms" since 2053	Suppressed. Survives underground.
HEARTLAND	The Anointing	The women wash and braid the bride's hair, each speaking a private word over her	"The most tender thing the Empire accidentally preserved"
HEARTLAND	Planting	After a burial the community plants something that will come back	Approved in 2058

WHICH OF THESE MY CHARACTERS HAVE DONE, SEEN OR ONLY HEARD ABOUT

What people actually practice, continued

TKC: DOM · MEN

DOMINION	PRACTICE	WHAT IT IS	THE EMPIRE'S POSITION
RED EARTH	The Second Covenant	The morning after a Binding, a mother tells her daughter what the first covenant means and what she may keep for herself	Unrecorded, word for word across the Dominion
RED EARTH	Score coaching	For twenty years mothers have taught high-scoring sons how much ability to show	Never documented
RED EARTH	Sitting with the dead	Women sit with the body in shifts. Burial at midday.	Never understood, so never regulated
LONE	The Giving, the First Ride	The bride receives something of her grandmother's. A girl navigates a long distance alone.	Never acknowledged
LONE	Boots	The dead are buried with boots on	Approved without being understood
MOUNTAIN	The Witness Walk	A couple walks alone in the mountains before the ceremony	Unregulated

WHICH OF THESE MY CHARACTERS HAVE DONE, SEEN OR ONLY HEARD ABOUT

TKC: DOM · MEN

WHAT PEOPLE ACTUALLY PRACTICE, CONTINUED

DOMINION	PRACTICE	WHAT IT IS	THE EMPIRE'S POSITION
MOUNTAIN	The name to the mountain	A death prayer said once, with the name spoken to the mountain	Unregulated
SABLE	Desert names	Every woman has two names, one for the Empire and one for the house. A girl earns hers at the Finding.	Doesn't know they exist
SABLE	The Desert Walk, fire burials	A couple's night alone in the desert. The name said once into a fire left to burn out.	Unregulated
PACIFIC	The Real Binding	A private ceremony with the promises the couple actually means	Unregistered
PACIFIC	Facing West	A boy faces the ocean at dawn, then turns back to the city. The dead are buried facing west.	Ignored until the Empire gave up in 2078

WHICH OF THESE MY CHARACTERS HAVE DONE, SEEN OR ONLY HEARD ABOUT

Faith that isn't performance

TKC: DOM · WR 26 · DR3 · AM

INFERENCE Where the files don't say how the Empire treats a practice, the column reads "Unregulated."

THE BLIND SPOT

The files don't make every believer a dupe. Heartland faith is genuine, and its women call their questions about the Commonwife designation theological inquiry and mean it (DOM). Ruth Gideon "believes the Empire more than Eden does," sincere without being foolish (WR 26). Eden's own faith is real and "required more maintenance" than Maribel Vale's (DR3). Celeste is the most religious person in the book and the least Imperial (AM). INTERPRETATION The Empire approves what it's already lost and tolerates what makes money. What women do in kitchens, at bedsides and the night before a wedding mostly goes unseen. Celeste's whole faith is built in that blind spot, and the novel's religious line runs between faith the Temple can use and faith that answers to something it doesn't control.

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

PART IX LOG

Working Questions

1 · WHAT DOES THE COVENANT OF DISSENT ARGUE, AND WHICH LINE WOULD GET SOMEONE ARRESTED TODAY?

2 · WHAT HAPPENS TO A WOMAN CAUGHT PERFORMING A SALT CEREMONY, IF ANYONE EVER HAS BEEN? HAS EDEN ATTENDED ONE?

3 · WHAT DID THE MEN TELL ZION AT HIS SPEAKING? ONE LINE EDEN WILL NEVER HEAR.

4 · IS THERE AN AUREM EQUIVALENT OF THE READING CIRCLES OR THE KITCHEN, A NETWORK CELESTE BELONGS TO?

5 · WHAT HYMNS DOES THE TEMPLE APPROVE, AND WHAT DO THE OUTER DISTRICTS SING INSTEAD?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

6 · WHAT DOES A HEARTLAND WOMAN'S THEOLOGICAL INQUIRY INTO THE COMMONWIFE DESIGNATION ACTUALLY ARGUE? THIS MATTERS FOR RUTH.

TKC: CR · MEN · FR 1 · FR 19 · TR · DOM · TL

What each woman is

Since the Restoration Act of 2041, a woman's citizenship has depended on her marital status (**TL**). The Empire controls women by telling each one what she is and making that classification the frame of her whole life (**MEN**).

Anointed Wife
WIFE OF A COVENANT MAN · THE TRIALS' PRODUCT · LOST AT WIDOWHOOD

Stewardwife
THE ADMINISTRATIVE CLASS

Bonded Wife
WIFE OF A BONDED MAN (INFERENCE)

Commonwife
A REGISTRATION STATUS (FR 1) · QUOTAS · TEMPLE REVIEW

Vowed
TEMPLE SERVICE · LEFT BY MARRIAGE

Unbound
UNMARRIED · "DIFFICULT AND SURVEILLED"

Ungoverned
OUTSIDE THE SYSTEM · CRIMINAL SINCE 2062

What each woman is, continued

TKC: CR · MEN · FR 1 · FR 19 · TR · DOM · TL

THE WIDOWED COVENANT	Because the designation belongs to the marriage, an Anointed widow holds a temporary status for two years that keeps most protections. She's expected to remarry within the class or drop to Stewardwife. The senior Anointed Wives run a network so efficient that no widow has ever fallen below Stewardwife (**CR**).
THE SIX	**INFERENCE** Older notes describe a six-tier caste system. Leaving out the Ungoverned, the six are Anointed, Stewardwife, Bonded, Commonwife, Vowed and Unbound. **OPEN QUESTION** Is that the six, what's the official order, and where does Vowed rank?

CAN A WOMAN MOVE UP, OR ONLY DOWN? WHERE EACH DOOR LOCKS

TKC: DOM · DR3 · DECIDED

Designation

Every girl is assessed and given an initial classification. In Aurem it happens at eighteen, by a Vowed officer, testing literacy, theological knowledge and "domestic aptitude." The result is the Unbound track or the elevated track, which means better education and a chance at Covenant Daughter consideration (DOM).

DOMINION	WHEN AND HOW
AUREM	At 18, by a Vowed officer
GULF	At 14, the Procession
ARDENNE	Standard in Ashford. Hollow children tested when they can be brought in.
MERIDIAN	Three-day sessions: theology, written reasoning, policy, "relational compliance"
VANE	At 16, the Broadcast Assessment, partly filmed
IRONGATE	At 14 the Placement, at 18 Imperial Designation
HEARTLAND	At 13, the First Covenant, where her track is set in public
RED EARTH	At 18, two weeks in Temple spaces, Crown facilities and "domestic simulation environments"
LONE	At 16 in Covenant Basin. The First Ride outside it.
MOUNTAIN	At 16, with a physical assessment. Girls chosen for classified Vowed service disappear from public life.
SABLE	At 18 in Sable Reach. The Finding outside it.
PACIFIC	At 18. Every score reviewed in the Crownward for signs of inherited resistance.

THE AURELIA BOARD	Administration, Education, Domestic Service, Housekeeping, Food Service, Binding Recommendation and Remedial Instruction. Strong doctrine can lead to Temple Administration, strong household judgment to a Binding recommendation, and girls who test well everywhere to professional placement (DR3).
LEAH	DECIDED Leah sat for an assessment. Bell offered to nominate her "for Home Instruction the following year" as a consolation (DR3). OPEN QUESTION What is Home Instruction?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

LEAH'S ASSESSMENT DAY, FROM HER SIDE

TKC: TL · DOM · DR3 · CR · AM

Marriage as designation

The Binding is marriage as a legal and theological designation (**TL**). In Aurem it's held in a Temple, witnessed by a Vowed officiant, and registered with the Crown and the Temple at once. The bride wears white and gold and takes a surname hyphenated with her husband's. Ministers sign Binding certificates beneath each husband's name (**DR3**).

The Aurem Binding

Nobody asks if she consents. They ask if she is worthy. The correct answer is yes.

✣

DOM

ACROSS THE DOMINIONS	Meridian's is the most legally elaborate, with registration that can take three weeks. Red Earth's is the most surveilled, with Vowed witnesses at every one. Mountain adds Crown officers. Sable Reach binds at dawn. Gulf keeps its music. In the Crownward a Commonwife Binding is a short registration at the Crown office, and an Administrative Class Binding is recorded for the Broadcast (**DOM**, **CR**).
THE IMPERIAL BINDING	Seven public stages: the Declaration, Covenant Week, the Anointing (a private ceremony on the sixth day in which the Prelate anoints the bride), the Binding Night, the Grand Binding (four hours in the Sanctum), the Procession down Sovereign Boulevard, and the Private Supper, five guests at most. The bride's vows are twice as long as the heir's. The Empire calls that theology. In practice it's a legal document spoken aloud in a sacred building (**CR**).
NAMES	**OPEN QUESTION** Does the hyphenated surname apply only in Aurem? Celeste never took a Binding name, so she's still a Parish (**AM**). Miriam's would be something like Parish-Osei.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT AN AUREM BRIDE ACTUALLY SAYS WHEN SHE'S ASKED IF SHE'S WORTHY

TKC: DOM · TL · MEN · FR 0 · FR 3 · FR 16 · FR 19 · FR 28 · CR · TR

Two ends of the ladder

COMMONWIFE MARRIAGE	How the Empire marries off the labor class. Aurem has the highest Commonwife rate, because the Empire made marriage look like the highest honor available there (**DOM**). A Commonwife is expected to conceive within the Covenant timeline. A Vowed officer conducts quarterly household assessments, and two years without a pregnancy brings informal comments first and then Temple review (**MEN**, **TL**). (Volume Two, Leah.)
REASSIGNMENT	When a husband abandons his Commonwife, she can be reassigned to another man's household. It happened to Miriam after Thomas left (**FR 0**). Thomas left voluntarily (**FR 3**). Celeste has no proof Miriam is alive (**FR 16**). **OPEN QUESTION** Who decides it, what is her status during it, and why did Solomon keep the Osei name?
ANOINTED WIVES	All thirty-nine Trials place Anointed wives, and the Crown contest is a layer on top. One woman goes to the heir, the other eleven are married down the elite ladder, and nobody goes home unassigned (**FR 19**). The husbands are chosen by the oversight committee and ranked by standing. A man can't reject the woman assigned to him, but he can decline the assignment altogether, which removes him from the ladder. It has happened twice (**FR 28**).
THE ARRANGEMENT	Among the Anointed Court, male headship is mostly performance. Wives manage the information, relationships and social intelligence that make their husbands' positions work, and surface the right idea in private so the husband can present it in public. They never take credit or contradict him in public. New Anointed Wives learn it in the first year. Lyris runs the whole network, inherited from the Anointed Wife who mentored her. Celeste told Eden about the Arrangement before she left Aurem (**CR**).

INFERENCE Ladies in Waiting, the third- and fourth-place finishers, stay in the Crownward in supporting roles (**TR**). Under FR 19 they'd also be married into elite households. Both hold if they're placed in Crownward households and serve the Anointed Wife too.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO THE TWO MEN WERE WHO DECLINED THEIR ASSIGNMENTS, AND WHAT HAPPENED TO THEM

TKC: TL · DR3 · FR 31 · FR 32 · DOM

Unbound, Ungoverned, and four households

UNBOUND	"Difficult and surveilled" (TL). An Unbound woman can head a household only through reclassification, and household paperwork still demands an adult male authority.
CHILDREN	The Empire classifies children by household registration, not parentage or appearance (FR 32). Hannah's daughter Naomi is eligible through Hannah's household and standing, whatever her father's status (FR 31).
THE UNGOVERNED	Women who chose exile over designation. Their deepest roots are in the Ardenne hollows, where some communities have lived outside the system for two or three generations. The Empire calls them criminals, and the mountain people call them something closer to saints. Crossings happen through the Sable desert. Lone interprets "Ungoverned" loosely and never files a full report. Saint Meridian has the largest population of sympathizers, people inside the system who leave gaps in it on purpose (DOM).

	CELESTE'S	LEAH'S	HANNAH'S	AN ANOINTED HOUSEHOLD
On the paper	Unbound, reclassified. A young man on the authority line.	Commonwife	A former Vowed woman's	Covenant man, Anointed Wife
Who decides				
What's assessed				
What's hidden				

POSSIBLE Each one is a different answer to the same law.

Working Questions

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

PART IX LOG

1 · WHAT EXACTLY IS THE COVENANT TIMELINE FOR CONCEPTION, AND WHAT HAPPENS AFTER TEMPLE REVIEW?

2 · HOW DOES COMMONWIFE REASSIGNMENT WORK, AND WHO IN AURELIA DECIDES IT?

3 · WHAT CAN AN UNBOUND WOMAN LEGALLY OWN, SIGN OR INHERIT?

4 · WHAT HAPPENS TO A WOMAN'S DESIGNATION IF HER HUSBAND IS CONVICTED, OR DECLARED UNGOVERNED?

5 · WHAT DO THE SENIOR ANOINTED WIVES DO FOR A WIDOW IN THOSE TWO YEARS?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

6 · HOW DOES A GIRL IN THE ARDENNE HOLLOWS END UP UNGOVERNED INSTEAD OF DESIGNATED, AND DOES ANYONE EVER GO BACK?